

This article explores the American ballad “Stackolee,” which recounts “Stack” Lee Shelton’s murder of his friend Billy Lyons on Christmas night in St. Louis in 1895. The study focuses on the ballad’s musical attributes and its combination with multiple formal patterns.

Unlike other murder ballads that emerged around the turn of the twentieth century, including “Frankie and Johnny,” “Railroad Bill,” and “Whitehouse Blues,” “Stackolee” does not associate exclusively with a particular musical pattern or scheme, instead intermingling with several. In this regard “Stackolee” resembles a “floating stanza,” a verse that crops up in many songs. But “Stackolee” is a “floating ballad,” because the entire song floats between different musical patterns. Like the ancient ballad “Barbara Allen,” “Stackolee” is, to use Charles Seeger’s term, “promiscuous,” because it associates with multiple musical frameworks rather than adhering to just one.

“Stackolee” appears in two main forms: a twelve-bar form, which combines with the “Frankie and Johnny” and “Railroad Bill” schemes, both ballad schemes that mostly support narrative songs about historical events; and an eight-bar form, which combines with the “How Long” scheme, which otherwise supports first-person lyric songs with conventional blues themes such as love and day-to-day life.

The ballad’s combination with different patterns demonstrates two different processes of lyrical development. Its association with the “Frankie” scheme shows how lyrics sometimes migrate between ballads that share the same pattern, whereas its combination with the “How Long” scheme shows how a separate lyrical branch may emerge where a ballad combines with a different scheme.